



Thor washing machine, c.1929



SPIN DRYER

In the 19th century, before the invention of dryers, most people dried clothes by hanging them outside or next to a fire. In the 1920s, electric dryers began to appear. They used a motor to spin clothes rapidly in a metal drum, which had holes in it to let the water escape. The dryers produced heat to dry the clothes, something that modern dryers also do.

Early German spin dryer, 1929



MODERN WASHING MACHINES

Today's washing machines are a vast improvement on the Thor. Their drums are positioned horizontally and spin at high speed to remove moisture from clothes. They have compartments for detergent (cleaning liquid) and fabric conditioner (which softens clothes), and a variety of programs to cope with different materials, ranging from wool to polyester.

DETERGENTS

Modern detergents are made of substances called surfactants—chemicals that work by pulling oil and grease into a water solution, allowing them to be washed off clothes. Discovered by German chemists during World War I, surfactants were refined in the 1940s by the American researcher David Byerly.



Packets of liquid detergent